

The Psychology of Gollum: A Two-Agent Bargaining Model of the Self

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The clinical literature treats Gollum as a cautionary tale about addiction. This is correct but incomplete. What the record actually documents — in unusual detail, thanks to two attentive hobbit observers — is a *bargaining game between two selves sharing one body*, and it rewards formal treatment.

The setup

Model the individual as two agents. **Sméagol** has conventional preferences: food, memory of sunlight, the approval of others. **Gollum** has a single dominant preference with an infinite reservation price. The two alternate control of the body — the observable “arguments” are, in this reading, negotiation rounds over the allocation of future control.

The Ring functions as an *asymmetric commitment device*: every period it strengthens Gollum’s bargaining position and erodes Sméagol’s outside option. After five hundred years, Sméagol’s threat point is approximately zero. That he negotiates anything at all is remarkable.

The Frodo intervention

The most interesting event in the dataset is exogenous: Frodo extends trust, addresses Sméagol by name, and — critically — creates *external* value for the Sméagol identity. For a period, the equilibrium visibly shifts: service is rendered, promises are kept, the Gollum agent is suppressed in daylight hours.

The mechanism matters for policy. Frodo did not strengthen Sméagol’s willpower (an intra-personal resource); he changed the *payoff structure* by making cooperation externally rewarded. Recovery, in this model, is not a triumph of will but a renegotiation under improved outside options.

The relapse, and the stairs of Cirith Ungol

The equilibrium collapses on contact with a third party who assigns the Sméagol identity zero value. One act of misrecognition — Sam’s accusation over the innocent matter of the rabbits — reprices Sméagol’s cooperative strategy to worthless, and Gollum resumes control permanently. Practitioners will recognise the pattern: the relapse is triggered not by the addictive good but by the withdrawal of the identity that made abstention worthwhile.

Implication

If the self is a coalition, treatment is coalition management. Punishing the whole individual strengthens precisely the agent you wish to weaken — a result this author has verified, at length, in committee.